

FINAL PBL ASSESSMENT

<https://www.channelnewsasia.com/today/voices/how-do-you-feel-when-your-text-message-received-not-replied-instantly-5546421>

Canva: <https://canva.link/xsqnlp9v237cs9f>

Why Does “seen” Seem Like an Answer?

Hook

“Seen.”

Just four letters, but somehow those four letters can turn a completely normal Tuesday night into a full investigation.

You send someone a message, they see it, and then... nothing.

Five minutes later, you're fine.

Twenty minutes later, you're wondering what you did wrong.

An hour later, you've created approximately 47 possible explanations for why they haven't replied.

But here's the strange part: all you actually know is that they opened your message.

You don't know why they haven't replied.

You don't know what they're thinking.

You don't even know if they're ignoring you.

Yet somehow, “Seen” feels like an answer.

So how did technology turn such a small piece of information into something we interpret as a complete message?

Introduce the Idea

To explore this, I looked at a CNA article titled “How do you feel when your text message is received but not replied to instantly?”

- Published: January 4, 2019
- Author: David Cowan, a psychology lecturer at the University of Queensland
- Original source: The Conversation Topic: How read receipts, online status indicators, and instant messaging affect communication

The article explains that knowing someone has seen our message can change the way we interpret their silence.

So, can we trust this source to present the issue fairly? Mostly. The article is credible and informative, but I think it is slightly biased toward the negative effects of read receipts.

My Analysis

Language and Emotional Appeal

The first thing I noticed is the article's use of emotional language.

- It describes waiting for a reply as a “reply-status nightmare.”
- It discusses emotions such as anxiety, rejection, and discomfort.
- These words make read receipts feel more stressful than they might otherwise seem.

A read receipt simply tells us that someone opened our message. But describing the experience as a “nightmare” encourages the audience to associate the technology with negative emotions.

So, the article's language can influence how we feel about read receipts, rather than simply giving us neutral information about them.

What the Article Emphasizes

The second thing I noticed is what the article chooses to focus on.

The article emphasizes that read receipts can:

- Create pressure to reply
- Make people anxious
- Cause people to interpret silence as rejection

These are real concerns, but there is another side.

Read receipts can also be useful. For example, if you're waiting for someone to receive an important message, knowing that they have actually seen it can give you reassurance.

However, this benefit receives much less attention in the article. So I don't think the article is unfair or misleading. Instead, its bias comes from emphasis. It gives more attention to the negative effects, which can make the audience see read receipts mainly as something that creates anxiety.

Credibility vs Bias

At the same time, the article has reasons to be considered credible.

- The author has a background in psychology.
- The article discusses psychological effects rather than relying only on personal opinions.
- It provides an explanation for why people may react differently to read receipts.

However, being credible does not mean being completely unbiased.

A source can provide accurate information while still choosing certain language, examples, or perspectives over others.

In this case, the information may be reliable, but the way it is presented encourages us to focus more on the negative side of read receipts.

Reflection

This brings me back to my original question: Why does "Seen" seem like an answer?

Maybe because technology has changed what we consider information.

Before read receipts, if someone didn't reply, we simply didn't know whether they had seen the message.

Now, we know they probably have.

But that tiny piece of information feels like it should explain everything else.

It doesn't.

"Seen" tells us that someone opened the message.

It doesn't tell us why they haven't replied.

The rest is something we interpret ourselves.

And I think that's what makes the CNA article interesting.

It isn't simply telling us that read receipts exist.

Through its language and emphasis, it can also influence how we interpret them.

Final Takeaway

So, can we trust this source to present the issue fairly?

Mostly.

The article is credible and informative, but I would still consider it slightly biased toward the negative effects of read receipts because of its emotional language and the perspective it emphasizes.

But there's a bigger lesson here: Bias doesn't always mean that information is false.

Sometimes, it's about which part of the truth gets the spotlight.

And the same thing can happen with our own messages.

When we see "Seen 8:42 PM," we know one thing: They saw it.

Everything else is a story we create.

So maybe "Seen" isn't actually an answer. It's a question mark disguised as one.